new, uncharted territory. For the first time, the party was in a position to capture power on its own in Gujarat.

As the results began to trickle in—and this was the pre-electronic voting machine era, so the counting was much slower—there was an air of great expectancy at the BJP party headquarters in Khanpur in Ahmedabad. By the evening, it was becoming clearer that the BJP was on its way to a famous win. The party eventually won a two-thirds majority with 121 of the 182 seats. The leaders were cheered as they entered the party office. Keshubhai Patel was the man anointed as chief minister; other senior leaders like Shankersinh Vaghela and Kashiram Rana all shared traditional Gujarati sweets and *farsan*. In a corner was Modi, the man who had scripted the success by managing the election campaign down to the last detail. The arc lights were on the BJP's other senior leaders, but I remember an emotional Modi telling me on camera that 'this is the happiest moment in my life'. The almost anonymous campaign manager seemed to sublimate himself to his party with the fierce loyalty of the karyakarta.

On 19 March 1995, Keshubhai Patel was sworn in as the first BJP chief minister of Gujarat at a function in Gandhinagar. Again, Modi wasn't the focus, but already the whispers in party circles projected him as the 'super-chief minister'. The sweet smell of success, though, would quickly evaporate. The Sangh Parivar in Gujarat became the Hindu Divided Parivar and the party with a difference began to weaken because of internal differences. By October that year, a rebellion within the BJP led by Vaghela forced Keshubhai to resign. A compromise formula was evolved—Suresh Mehta was made the chief minister of Gujarat, and Modi, who was accused by his detractors of fomenting the politics of divide and rule in the state, was packed off to north India as the national secretary in charge of Haryana and Himachal Pradesh.

These were Modi's years in political *vanvas* (exile). He could have dived into his new challenge, but his heart was always in Gujarat. 'He still wants to be the chief minister of Gujarat one day, that is his ultimate ambition,' a common friend told me on more than one occasion. If that was his final destination, Modi kept it well concealed. Once ensconced in Delhi, Modi